

**TAU**

First draft – as of 11 August 2026

untitled.movie

## Sequence 1 – The Night (pretitle, ~3 min)

BLACK.

The sound of a house at night: wood working. Wind in a chimney. Very far away: a dog.

### INT. HIDEOUT, LIVING ROOM – NIGHT

*"The World of Undersides" · "The Knock" · "The Arm in the Light" · "*

Floorboards, very close. A strip of light lies across them and does not tremble.

We are at floor level, under a table. Of the world there are only undersides: chair legs. The hem of a curtain. A kerosene lamp standing on the floor, throwing a yellow circle. In the circle, among the things: a small glass vial with a beautiful stopper.

Two voices whisper, a woman, a man. No words, only sound – the sound of people who have spoken quietly for years and are good at it.

Then, for the length of one breath, the woman's whisper becomes language:

MOTHER (O.S.)  
(whispering)  
... high above everything a place.  
You take the path that turns...

A KNOCK.

The whispering stops.

A bolt. A door opens.

FATHER (O.S.)  
(loud – loud for the first  
time)  
... !

NOTE ON SOUND: The father has seen who is standing there, and the first moment is a good one: he says a single word – a name. It does not sound like fear. It sounds like recognition, almost like joy that should know better. The word is spoken, not slurred; but room, furniture and heartbeat lie between us: it does not come through. Not on first viewing, not on second. Only in the third return of the night (scene 55) does it become almost language – two syllables.

A man's legs in the doorframe: work boots, wet trouser hems that stop dripping. A voice – too deep to hold words – breaks. Starts again. Breaks.

Then an arm stretches into the light of the lamp. In the hand: a gun. Above the wrist, where the sleeve slides back, a dark sign on the skin. Small. Shaped like the shadowy head of a horse.

The child under the table: four years old, a face in the half-dark. It looks at the sign.

The first SHOT: only a jolt of the light and a fall. We are on the child's face and we stay there.

At the second, something throws itself between – a skirt, a familiar fabric. The floor shudders. Once.

Then the world stands still. The boots stay. Longer than boots are allowed to stay. A sound, perhaps a whimper.

Then they are gone.

The lamp keeps burning. The yellow circle. The vial still stands.

BLACK.

**TITLE: [untitled]**

## **Sequence 2 – The Home (~11 min)**

HARD CUT:

### **INT. DORMITORY, THE HOME – PRE-DAWN**

*"Listening to the House"*

A face, fourteen years old, awake. ANNA.

No title card. No transition. Whoever saw the four-year-old must make the leap themselves – and makes it on this face.

A dormitory, thirty beds. All the sleepers about the same age, fourteen, fifteen – as if someone had locked up an entire school and forgotten the years before and after.

Anna lies still, eyes open, and listens to the house:

A floorboard creaks, far away. Her eyes follow. A key, two doors down. Her eyes follow. A cough, a second one – she knows before we do which bed the third will come from.

### **EXT. YARD, THE HOME / SKY – DAY**

*"The Drops"*

A SIREN. Doors slam, thirty children run into the yard as

if they had never done anything else.

In the sky: a helicopter drops padded crates. The DROPS.

The crates hit the ground. The children are there first, opening, sorting, carrying – a practiced system with rules nobody explains.

The GROWN-UPS arrive last: few, grey, thin, all in long sleeves despite the sun.

**EXT./INT. YARD / STOREROOM – DAY**

*"The Sixteen"*

The storeroom: shelves with a few Drops rations, two lists on a nail.

The last two of the ten crates are set down by two children. A HOUSEPARENT (50s, fleshy face, quick hands) counts them off with his chin. Arrogant and disdainful, he watches them.

On one crate, sticking to the underside: a SLIP OF PAPER. Cleanly printed, from over there – a leftover from the packing that nobody over there removed. Beneath signs that are nobody's business here, a number:

**16**

The houseparent sees the slip. Tears it off in passing, without changing stride, and lets it vanish into his pocket. Quick hands.

Anna sees it.

**EXT. YARD, THE HOME – LATER**

*"Half the Ration"*

At the edge of the yard. A BOY plants himself in front of Anna, half a loaf of bread in his hand. He holds it out, half offer, half question.

BOY

The sugar.

Anna looks at the bread. Then at him.

ANNA

The room behind the coal chute.  
Third crate. Under the empty ones.

The bread changes owners. The boy leaves.

Anna eats half. The other half she wraps up and hides –

behind a loose brick.

**INT. CLASSROOM, THE HOME – DAY**

*"The Dictation"*

Thirty lowered heads. A MATRON (60s, grey, long sleeves) dictates in a voice that has dictated this too many times:

MATRON

... destroyed by the terrorist  
attack – comma – which the traitor  
Jahn – J-a-h-n – committed against  
his own city – full stop.

On the wall: a yellowed poster. The JAHN works, proud, seen from below; in front of it, small, four people with flags. Three of the faces someone has scratched out with a pencil – years ago, the grey has long gone shiny. The fourth nobody has touched: a young woman, a child on her arm.

MATRON (CONT'D)

From justice he removed himself, a  
casualty of his own deed.

Anna takes the dictation neatly. Beautiful, even handwriting. Her face says nothing.

**INT. STOREROOM – DAY**

*"The Jacket"*

His jacket hangs over the edge of a crate while the houseparent stacks. Anna walks past; once, her hand brushes the jacket. It looks like nothing.

**INT. THE CARETAKER'S ROOM – DAY**

*"The Almost-Mark"*

Anna walks along a corridor; from a small room comes a whimpering.

A narrow room, a bed, a smell of cold smoke. The CARETAKER (old, grey) lies in the corner.

CARETAKER

Water,

Anna does not hesitate long. Beside the caretaker stands a small cup. She takes it, goes out and comes back. She hands it to the sick man.

As he drinks, his sleeve slides back. A strip of skin above the wrist: something dark, several of them. We are too far away to see shapes.

Anna is not. Her gaze rests on the strip of skin, two seconds, three – then the cup is empty, the sleeve is down, her gaze is elsewhere.

She disappears without a word.

**INT. NOOK UNDER THE STAIRS, THE HOME – DAY**

*"The Notebook"*

Anna's place: a niche under the stairs, with a view of two escape routes.

She has the dictation in front of her – and turns the page over. On the back she draws, from memory, with a hard pencil: a small sign. The one from the caretaker's wrist.

She looks at it. She compares it to nothing that we see.

Then she crosses it out – one stroke, clean, final.

Then we see THE NOTEBOOK whole: a thick, self-bound thing made of other people's paper – sheets printed on one side, dictations, forms, all written on from the back. Pages upon pages of small signs, every one crossed out.

At the very front a first page, older than everything else, soft-worn at the edge.

Anna leafs past it without opening it.

**EXT. HOME ADMINISTRATION, WINDOW – EVENING**

*"The Nail"*

Anna passes outside the open window of the administration – for a moment there is a slip of paper in her hand, then there is none. You can see it. You do not have to.

**INT. DORMITORY – NIGHT**

*"The Mother's Story"*

Anna starts out of sleep. No sound. Only her breath, too fast, and her hand already on the bed frame before she is awake.

We do not see the dream.

She lies back, stares into the dark. Then her lips begin to move – soundless, practiced. We hear scraps, less than a whisper:

ANNA  
 (barely audible)  
 ... high above everything ... the  
 whole city ... and in the evening  
 comes the –

She stops.

She starts again, reaches the same place, stops.

Then, instead of going on, she begins to count. Her lips form numbers, soundless, one after another, the way other people count sheep.

That is how she falls asleep.

**INT. CORRIDOR, THE HOME – DAY**  
*"The Pencil"*

Anna walks down the corridor – and stops. In front of her stands a man she did not hear coming.

THE PENCIL (50s, long, thin, grey – the children's nickname explains itself).

He holds out a bundle of paper to her without a word. Old paper, printed on one side, neatly tied.

Anna takes it.

He walks on as if nothing had happened.

**EXT. YARD, THE HOME – DAY**  
*"The Reckoning"*

The MATRON comes striding fast toward the HOUSEPARENT, stomping.

MATRON  
 Hey!

She holds his list in one hand and waves the houseparent over. In the other: the slip with the 16.

The houseparent understands at once.

The children sense that something is off and gather around the two of them.

She is not loud. She only reads out.

MATRON

It says here: sixteen pieces.

(beat)

There were ten crates.

(she raises the list)

Your list says: one hundred and fifty. Always one hundred and fifty.

The children say nothing. Thirty pairs of eyes do the arithmetic. It is not a hard sum – and it calculates itself backward through the years.

HOUSEPARENT

Fifteen. There were always fifteen in there. Always. Ask – ask anyone you like –

(faster)

They print it wrong. What do they know, over there

– there were spoiled ones in there, I took those out, that's not on there –

Who –

He breaks off.

The silence of thirty children is not a quiet sound.

MATRON

(to the room)

To your places. All of you.

Nobody goes. Not hostile. Just: nobody goes.

The matron looks from the children to the papers in her hand. She is the only one who understands at once what has just come to an end here.

Anna stands nearby. She watches.

# **INT. THE LITTLE ONES' DORMITORY – EVENING**

*"The Imitation"*

FIVE LITTLE ONES (the youngest: 3, 7, 10, 12 and 12) crowded onto one bed.

Anna stands in the aisle between the beds. And does the houseparent:

The walk – arrogant, disdainful gaze. Then the pious face, the upward glance when he lies.

Soundless. Exact. Devastating.

The little ones laugh. First one, then all of them – the smothered, snorting laughter of children who know they could be heard.

Anna does not laugh. She does a second round: the thief sliding a ration into his sleeve while glancing piously upward. The little ones nearly shriek.

At the door, in the dark of the corridor, stands one of the BIG ONES, watching. He does not laugh.

**EXT. YARD, THE HOME – MORNING**  
*"The Revolt"*

At the food distribution a BIG ONE reaches across the table and takes what is not his. The THIEVING HOUSEPARENT holds on to the crate – two seconds, then the boy tears it out of his hands, and the grown-up falls. Too easily. Frighteningly easily.

After that it goes fast: crates changing owners; a door kicked off its hinges; children striking out at houseparents, other houseparents trying to flee. Somewhere something small is burning that nobody puts out.

Fourteen-year-olds are not children you can stop. The old have no strength.

Anna leads nothing. She stands in the smoke at the edge of the yard, the notebook already under her arm, and watches – not triumphant, not frightened. Keeping records.

**EXT. GATE, THE HOME – DAY**  
*"The Open Gate"*

The gate stands open. Nobody guards it anymore.

Anna walks through, without running. The notebook under one arm, the bundle with the half ration under the other.

In the doorway of the side wing – ARCHIVE is written above the door, in old paint – stands the Pencil, watching her go.

He does not raise his voice. He raises nothing at all. He only stands so that she knows he has seen her.

Beyond the gate: the city. Grey, staggered.

She walks in.

### Sequence 3 – The City (~15 min)

#### EXT. STREETS – DAY

##### *"The Rules"*

The city by day: emptier than a city is allowed to be, and not empty enough to be dead.

Anna walks – and learns.

At a corner: a CHALK X, hip-high, retraced many times. Ahead of Anna a shrouded FIGURE with a bucket turns off without looking at the X. Anna turns off too, following.

A well with a bucket on it, upside down. The figure does not draw water here; it walks two streets further to a well without a bucket. Anna memorizes both.

Doors with signs hanging at them – on the post, at hand height: a strip of cloth, a piece of tin, once a child's shoe.

In front of these doors you walk on the other side of the street. Anna walks on the other side of the street.

Nobody explains anything. Anna asks nothing. We learn the way she learns: by watching.

#### EXT. BLANK WALL – DAY

##### *"Can You Still Smell It?"*

A windowless wall, six stories high. On it, huge and faded: an ADVERTISING POSTER.

A glass flacon, perfect of form. A flower, painted like a promise. And a sign, curved like a signature – the Greek letter: τ. Beneath it, in elegant lettering: TAU.

Across it, in tar, in letters that dripped as they were written:

#### CAN YOU STILL SMELL IT?

Anna walks past without reading.

#### EXT./INT. OLD DISTILLERY – DAY

##### *"The Drum Room"*

A long brick building behind a courtyard wall, dead chimneys. Above the gate, in old paint, a remnant of the curved sign: τ.

Anna is looking for wire. She climbs in through a window

that is no longer one.

Inside: gutted halls. What was wood has been burned; what was metal has been built into other things. The city has eaten this house like all the others.

Anna works her way through the rubble, practiced. At a dead machine she finds what she needs: wire, spring-hard, arm-long. She coils it up.

Then, at the end of a corridor: a door that is still one.

It opens without a sound. In this house, that stands out: somebody oils these hinges.

Behind it: DRUMS.

Two dozen, lined up against the wall, skinned and taut, the heads dull with grease. No dust. Dust lies over this whole city – not here.

Anna stands in the doorway and touches nothing. Her gaze does what her gaze always does: counts, files away. What this is, nobody tells her. Nobody tells us either.

She pulls the door shut, as quietly as you shut doors in other people's houses.

On the way back, across the courtyard: the COURTYARD WALL. Names, written in chalk, one beneath the other – some weathered, some fresh.

Anna walks past without reading.

#### **EXT. WASTELAND – DAY**

*"The Dog"*

Anna, motionless behind a remnant of wall, a wire snare in her hand, her eyes on a PIGEON pecking among the rubble.

She throws. Too late –

Something yellow is faster. A DOG, thin, yellow, takes the pigeon mid-leap, lands, stands.

He does not eat. He looks at Anna, the pigeon in his jaws.

Anna looks at the dog. And you can watch her calculate – it is the same face as with the sugar, the thief, the lists: meat for two days. Or that – what he just did – every day.

She crouches down. Waits. The dog comes, in a wide arc, and does not put the pigeon down – but he lets Anna lay her hand on it.

She shares. Half, half. He eats his at once. She wraps hers up.

The dog stays.

**EXT. ALCOVE BETWEEN TWO HOUSES – NIGHT**

*"Without Calculation"*

Anna sleeps sitting up, her back against the wall. The dog lies behind her, a warm half-circle around her back.

Half asleep, the dog lays his head on her leg.

Anna's hand is in his fur before she notices. For a moment her face is fourteen years old and nothing else – no bookkeeping, no calculation.

She notices. Startles. Pulls her hand away.

The dog lifts his head, looks at her.

She puts her hand back.

**EXT. NICHE BETWEEN TWO HOUSES – MORNING**

*"The Morning Below"*

The smell wakes her before the light does. The dog is gone.

At the mouth of the niche, one step from her feet: human filth. Fresh. Somebody was here in the night, that close.

Anna gets up, the bundle already in her hand. The disgust is one thing.

The other: she heard nothing. She, who in the home heard every key two doors away, slept through somebody coming within a step of her.

Down here you sleep like a thing left by the road.

Her gaze goes up, along the facades.

The dog comes around the corner, a rat in his jaws.

**EXT. CHURCH – DAY**

Anna and the dog come to a church. The windows have been smashed in. She goes inside. The dog follows her.

**INT. CHURCH – DAY**

*"The Bicycle on the Altar"*

The church: high, cold, still. The light falls through

smashed-in, blind windows as if through milk.

Anna looks around, fascinated; she has never seen a room like this.

The pews are gone. In the dust, the pale rectangles where they stood – burned, row after row. On the side walls, an almost completely torn-off confessional.

On the altar lies a BICYCLE.

Scrap, eaten hollow like the houses: the spokes harvested, the tyres gone, the chain gone.

On the handlebar dangles the SPEEDOMETER, its cable still attached – a wire, hidden in a sheath.

Wire is wire. Anna takes the speedometer off and sets her knife to it: prying, turning. The housing does not give. Not at the first try. Not at the second.

She pockets it, cable and all.

**EXT./INT. ATTIC ABOVE A DEAD LANE – EVENING**  
*"Sleeping High"*

Anna climbs a facade nobody considers climbable anymore – drainpipe, ledge, window.

The attic: empty, dusty, high. Two ways out – the hatch to the lane, the skylight to the ridge. Anna checks both. Only then does she set down her bundle.

The notebook gets a hiding place: under a floorboard. The food gets another: behind the chimney flue, two rooms away.

In the corner lies something: a SPYGLASS. Small, brass, a dent in the tube – blind. Whoever looks through it sees milk. Deep inside the housing, something loose rattles.

Anna holds it to her eye.

Then she wraps it up and hides it – not with the ration, not with the notebook. A third hiding place. The best one.

She goes to the skylight, takes off her shoes and considers the right one in the moonlight. The sole is slowly coming loose. Then she sets it aside, carefully.

She lies down and looks into the lane below. Whoever sleeps high hears the city from above.

The dog has found the staircase she did not take. He lies down at the door as if that were his post.

**EXT. WASH HOUSE – DAY**

*"The Archive of Not-Finding"*

A low building at the end of a lane, and it does something no other house in this city does: it breathes. Steam from every crack, from blind windows, out from under the door.

People with bundles go inside. Anna stands on the other side of the street and watches. Beside her, the dog. She takes him into a side lane and hides him there behind a few barrels. With her hand she tells him to stay, and puts down a piece of bread for him. Then she goes to the wash house.

Baskets are stacked by the door. Beside the door a RACK, roughly built, full of shoes – pair beside pair, of everyone inside. Nobody guards it.

Anna takes off her shoes and puts them with the rest. Her hand stays a moment on the right one, the one with the loose sole. Then she lets go.

She picks up a basket and goes in, barefoot.

**INT. WASH HOUSE – DAY**

A single room, and the room is steam. Tubs, washboards, benches, gutters in the floor. At the far end of the room a low door, firelight behind it.

The door opens, and TWO MEN come in, between them a VAT on two poles, rags around the handles. The water steams. Behind them, for a moment: the FIRE ROOM – a blackened kettle, and beneath it the only fire in this city allowed to burn by day. It eats what the houses give up: chair legs, floorboards, a length of banister.

Hot water, in this city, exists exactly here. Nowhere else.

The men go along the tubs, topping up – one measure each.

The GROWN-UPS OF THE CITY, for the first time many at once. Many shrouded, long-sleeved, grey – the MARKED; they wash what a sleeve will yield: hands, face, the neck down to the collar. Others have stripped: bare arms, bare backs, skin in the steam. What rule lies behind it, you cannot see. You see only this: nobody looks.

And you see the order of the house, which nobody explains. Those who can wash themselves. The weak are washed – an OLD WOMAN who can no longer lift her arms, a MAN as thin as his stick. VOLUNTEERS wash them. Nobody assigns them, they come of their own accord. The hot water belongs to the weak first; nobody explains that either.

Anna sets the basket down. And watches.

The steam veils and unveils, in waves: arms, wrists, the strip of skin between glove and sleeve.

Anna organizes herself a rag. A bowl. The next time the vat comes past, she dips the bowl in like everyone else. It takes no two minutes, then she is kneeling among the volunteers, washing what is pushed her way – a hand, an arm, a back. A child that works is asked no questions here.

The old woman holds out her forearm to her like a piece of wood. On the inside: a MARK. Anna washes over it, once, twice. It does not come off. She looks at it – exactly as long as a washerwoman would look. No longer.

She does not look at faces. Only at forearms. One after the other, tub by tub.

**EXT./INT. WASH HOUSE – EVENING**

The dog lifts his head. Anna comes out of the wash house. He runs to her and walks along at her side.

**EXT./INT. ATTIC ABOVE A DEAD LANE – NIGHT**

Anna sits before a small fire that gives light; in front of her lies the dog. On a spit, a skinned rat.

Anna draws marks on paper from memory, looks at them and compares them in her head, and crosses them out, one after another.

She lays the notebook aside.

Anna looks over at the dog; he looks up at her.

ANNA

Nothing again.

She takes the rat and cuts it up with an old knife, throws a piece to the dog, and bites into her own share.

**EXT. GANG TERRITORY / MARKET – DAY**

*"The Toll"*

A square that was once a market and is one again – except that all the traders are fourteen. Stalls made of door panels, tolls at the entrances, rituals nobody explains.

Anna wants through. Two GANG BOYS step into her path, casually, the way a door swings shut.

She gives way to the left – there is a third. To the right: a stall, a wall. It looks like chance and is craft: three steps, and Anna stands in a corner from which the only way on is through the boys.

The dog beside her. Still, for now.

THE LEADER comes without hurry: fifteen, wiry. He appraises Anna. The bundle. The notebook under her arm.

LEADER  
What's that?

ANNA  
Paper.

He holds out his hand. Anna gives him the notebook.

The leader leafs through it. Crossed-out signs, page after page. He glances at Anna – a look like a shrug: mad, but worthless. He hands it back.

Then he nods to the boys. One reaches for Anna's bundle.

Under Anna's jacket, at the waistband: the old knife. Her hand lies on it without our having seen it go there.

She calculates – faster than you can breathe; we only see it because we know this face by now: three in front of her, one beside, a wall at her back.

The hand comes out from under the jacket empty.

And then there is something YELLOW between Anna and the boys.

The dog. Low, the fur on his back a crest, teeth bared – and out of the thin body comes a sound nobody expected of him. The foremost boy snatches his hand back. The dog snaps – air, close. A warning, not a wound.

The boys give way. All but one.

The leader has stayed where he is. He looks at the dog.

LEADER  
He hunts.

It is not a question. Anna does not answer. That is answer enough.

LEADER  
The dog, then.

Anna looks at the dog.

The dog still stands between her and the boys. Ready. He is waiting for a sign from her – and whatever it says, he will do it.

Anna calculates.

She raises her hand. Flat, calm, downward: stay.

The dog stays. A gang boy lays the rope over him, carefully, with respect for the teeth.

At the edge of the square, a boy who sits bent over a trap has lifted his head. The spring between his fingers stands still.

From the boy's point of view: Anna does not turn around. She walks through the entrance they now clear for her and grows smaller between the stalls.

The boy watches her go.

At one of the stalls she stops: crockery, harvested from dead houses – pots, spoons, a TIN CUP with a dented rim.

Anna unwraps her bread, breaks off half and lays it on the door-leaf. The TRADER (fourteen, like everyone here) looks at the bread, then at her. Then he takes it.

The cup disappears into Anna's bundle.

**EXT. EDGE OF THE TERRITORY – DAY**

*"The Mended Sole"*

Anna passes the stall of the boy who just watched her go. She looks at him:

A BIG BOY making himself small, bent over a trap.

The boy glances up at her briefly; their eyes meet. Caught, he turns away and busies himself with the trap again – a bracket, a spring, a mechanism he tenses and releases with two fingers, tenses and releases.

As she passes, he looks at her shoes.

JAKOB. But we do not know that yet.

**EXT. WELL WITHOUT A BUCKET – DAY**

*"The Well"*

The good well, two streets past the one with the upturned bucket.

Four of the MARKED stand in line, with cans and jugs, at the distance this city keeps between everyone.

Anna joins the end of the line, her tin cup in her hand.

Then the line moves. Not forward – apart.

The last one steps aside. The woman before him too. One after another, wordless, without looking at Anna: a lane of waiting people, and at its end the well.

Anna stands still. You can watch her looking for the price. She finds none.

At the winch her gaze catches: the handle new, the rope freshly spliced – wire work, neat as seams. Two seconds, three.

She draws water, fills her cup and holds the well bucket out to the first in the line. He nods and takes it. She goes and drinks. Behind her the line closes again, as if nothing had happened.

#### **EXT. WASH HOUSE – DAY**

The breathing house. The baskets by the door.

Anna puts her shoes on the rack – without looking, with the grip of a habit – picks up a basket and goes in.

The steam takes her, as the house takes everyone.

#### **INT. ATTIC – EVENING**

Anna comes "home" and sits down. She takes off her shoes. Stops.

The torn sole of the right one: mended. Properly, with wire and a piece of rubber.

Anna looks at the sole for a long time. She does not know when it happened. Neither do we.

Her gaze goes to the door. To the empty spot where the dog used to lie.

For the first time since the home she looks as if something had escaped her.

### **Sequence 4 – The Boy (~15 min)**

#### **EXT. GANG TERRITORY, WORKSHOP CORNER – DAY**

*"The Mender"*

Anna comes back. Her sole has been mended, and she does not know what it cost – open accounts she can bear less well than hunger. The pretext: a rusty padlock without a key, which she lays on the plank in front of Jakob.

He takes it without asking where from, what for.

Anna waits for the question. For any question. None comes. She sits down on a barrel that stands by his stall.

While he works, we see his place in the tribe:

A gang boy brings a cart with a broken axle and leaves it without a word. The leader collects his trap, tensioned, oiled. He inspects it, tests it, makes a half turn and gives Jakob a respectful nod.

Jakob is the tolerated one, the one who makes things run. The only one, his whole bearing says, who was taken in here without a beating.

He wears a jacket that almost fits him. Almost – the way things almost fit that you grow into.

The lock springs open. He hands it to her, with the new key made of wire.

Anna lays a half pigeon on the plank, wrapped – the toll you lay for work in this city.

Jakob looks at the little bundle. Then he pushes it back, with one finger, and goes on working.

#### **EXT./INT. THE HOUSE WITH THE CHILD'S SHOE – DAY**

*"The Second Shoe"*

The door with the CHILD'S SHOE on the post. We know it. You walk on the other side of the street.

Anna stands on the other side of the street and watches. For a long time, the way she watches: on the chimney a bird's nest. The windows blind for years. No path in the rubble before the door.

She crosses the street. And goes in.

INSIDE: dust like snow. A living room nobody moved out of – it simply came to an end.

Anna works quietly and fast, with the hands of the practiced: a candle stub. A piece of rubber. Matches, swollen, perhaps still good. What burns and what mends. Everything else she leaves.

Then the second door.

A CHILD'S ROOM. A bed too small for anyone this city still has.

Anna studies the door frame: PENCIL MARKS, one above the other, each year a little higher. She traces them with her fingers.

They stop.

Anna stands in the doorway and takes: nothing.

She pulls the door shut the way you shut doors behind which someone is sleeping.

OUTSIDE: Anna steps into the street. In passing, with a movement that looks like nothing, she straightens the shoe on the post that was hanging crooked.

Then the street is empty. The shoe hangs straight.

**EXT. LANES / WASTELAND – DAY**

*"Crates from the Sky"*

A beating in the air, still far off.

The city reacts before we understand: doors, footsteps, running – children in front, out of every lane in the same direction, the marked behind them, as fast as their legs will give. For the first time, the whole city runs.

Anna runs with them.

THE WASTELAND. The HELICOPTER: high, too high for faces. It circles once, drops – padded crates, tumbling – and turns away before the first one hits. No wave, no sign. Over there throws the way you feed where you do not want to touch.

The gang is there first – of course it is there first. But nobody grabs anything for himself. The boys open the crates, count, stack; the scramble becomes a distribution, the running becomes a line.

The LEADER stands on a remnant of wall and conducts with his chin: those over there, open that one, you wait. At the market his gang takes toll. Not here. What the sky throws belongs to everyone first.

One crate bursts on impact. TINS roll, the little ones chase them – one of them catches a tin and lets it vanish into his jacket.

LEADER  
(without raising his  
voice)  
Back.

The boy puts the tin on the stack. Nobody looks at him for it.

The marked arrive last – and do not leave empty-handed: things have been set aside for them, without anyone having

said so.

Anna too receives her share, counted out, wordless – from the same boys who took her dog at the toll.

**EXT. GANG TERRITORY, WORKSHOP CORNER – DAY**  
*"The Speedometer"*

Anna comes. Jakob is waiting.

In front of him a plank across two barrels, tools on it, and beside them, wrapped in a cloth: the speedometer from the church – the thing Anna could not get the wire out of.

Jakob unwraps it. Round, glass, a needle at zero. He hands it over with both hands, solemnly, like a medal.

JAKOB

Fixed.

Anna turns the thing over. No crack, no rust. And no bicycle, anywhere – there are no bicycles left in this city.

ANNA

It doesn't show anything.

JAKOB

(gravely)

Zero. Exactly right.

Anna looks at him for a long time.

Then she stands differently – chin up, a half turn, paying him respect: the GANG LEADER, to the millimeter. Soundless. Exact.

Jakob's laughter comes too late. Then it comes entirely – the whole body, a laughter that falls over. He is embarrassed at once, right in the middle of it, and keeps laughing.

Anna smiles a little. She pockets the speedometer.

She leaves. Jakob looks after her. Anna looks back and, smiling, shakes her head.

JAKOB (calling)

What's your name?

She lifts the speedometer into the air.

ANNA

Anna!

Jakob looks eased. Then he sorts tools that are sorted.

**EXT. GANG TERRITORY, WORKSHOP CORNER – LATE AFTERNOON**  
*"The Half-Done Thing"*

The workshop corner. On the plank, half taken apart: the SPYGLASS – Anna's spyglass, at last a real defect. Lenses, rings, the empty tube: parts in a row only Jakob can read.

Jakob works. Anna sits on the second barrel, in a waiting position that has long stopped being one.

Then Jakob looks up – not at Anna: at the light. The stand of the sun above the roofs.

And packs up. Wordless, hurried, with an order that knows no haste and is haste anyway: parts into the cloth, cloth under his arm. He takes everything with him.

ANNA  
 Where are you going?

JAKOB  
 Have to go.

No invitation. No look back.

The boy has a clock in his body.

Anna stays seated for a moment, considering. Then she follows him.

**EXT. LANES – LATE AFTERNOON**  
*"To the Door"*

Through lanes she does not know. Jakob walks fast and naturally; Anna keeps her distance like an investigator.

A quarter, narrower, lower. Washing lines without washing. The door signs hang closer together here – a strip of cloth, a piece of tin, one every few houses.

Then a door. Jakob goes in without closing it, and climbs the stairs.

Anna stops. At the threshold. Then she follows him up.

**INT. WORKSHOP FLAT – LATE AFTERNOON**  
*"Ruth"*

From the door, with Anna: a room that is workshop and home at once. Tools on the wall, tidy. A bed by the window.

In the bed lies a WOMAN. RUTH (50s, built broad and made narrow by the illness; a face that has laughed a lot, and you can still see it).

Jakob already sits at her bed, a bowl of water beside him, washing her arms.

The arms are covered in marks. Many, old and new. Jakob washes them with the casualness of a boy who has never known anything else.

Anna, in the doorway, watches.

Ruth turns her head. Sees Anna. Seconds.

RUTH  
In or out. But don't stand there  
in the light – I don't have much  
of that left.

She steps across the threshold.

Ruth watches Jakob wring out the cloth.

RUTH  
He washes me every day. I tell  
him: boy, save yourself the  
trouble, the worms will take me  
dirty too.  
(pause)  
But no. Jakob wants it done  
properly.  
(to Anna, confiding)  
He doesn't get that from me.

Anna laughs. Short, through the nose, against her will – we do not know this laugh yet, it is as new as the room.

Jakob gets up, puts the bowl away and goes outside.

OUTSIDE, at the door: Jakob breathes. Once, twice, three times. Deep. Then he goes back in.

**INT. WORKSHOP FLAT – NIGHT**  
*"The Cot"*

The spyglass, half reassembled, on the workbench. It has grown late; the kerosene burns low.

Nobody sends Anna away.

She sits in the corner by the door. Ruth sleeps. Jakob tidies tools that are tidy.

In the other corner: a COT. Stretched flat, unused. A bed

on which a man should be lying who is not there. Beside it, on the floor: a folded blanket, a pillow on top – Jakob's place, a hand's breadth from the empty bed. Anna sees it. Catalogues it. Does not ask.

LATER: Anna, half asleep, on a blanket on the floor.

Next door, behind the thin wall: sounds. An awl through leather. Thread being pulled through. Even, practiced.

Anna falls asleep before she can decide what it is.

IN THE MORNING: The cot is as smooth as in the evening. On the workbench lies the spyglass. Finished. Nobody is there who could have been the one.

#### **EXT. MARKET – DAY**

*"The Line of Sight"*

The gangs' market, everyday life: trading, counting, tolls.

Somewhere in between: two GANG BOYS on the ground, a tangle of sleeves and dust. Then one tears free and runs – something in his fist. What, you cannot see.

The other picks himself up and shouts after him:

GANG BOY

Go to Jahn!

Nobody on the square turns their head.

Anna and Jakob at a stall – she is trading her half pigeon for potatoes and eggs, he is waiting.

At the other end of the square: movement. A MAN (gaunt, long sleeves), drunk – the slow, concentrated walk of a drunk who knows that everyone knows what he is. He crosses the market.

Jakob sees him first. Long before Anna could see him.

And then, casually, as if by chance: Jakob changes sides, takes half a step to the left, turns to Anna, shows her something at the stall – onions, a sieve, whatever.

He places himself exactly in her line of sight. He stays in it, with small corrections, until the man is off the square.

Anna has seen nothing.

**INT. WORKSHOP FLAT – DAY**

*"The Laugh"*

The flat has grown used to Anna. She sits in her place by the door; Jakob is looking for a tool he tidied away himself.

RUTH

The pair of you, honestly. One tidies up, the other guards my door.

(pause)

And keep the conversation down – I need my sleep.

Anna laughs. Through the nose, against her will.

And Ruth goes still.

She looks at Anna – too long, and suddenly quite clear and quite far away at once: the way you look at something that last stood in a room half a lifetime ago.

RUTH

Anna, let me look at you... It feels good, having you here. Finally there's laughter in this place again. I've missed having one like you.

ANNA

It used to be funnier here?

RUTH

Much. ...Long time ago.

They look at each other and smile.

**EXT. ROOF ABOVE THE LANE – EVENING**

*"Two Secrets, One Peace"*

Two children, a flat roof, remnants of food between them.

Anna's notebook lies beside her – the binding has come loose, the endpaper hangs.

Jakob sees it. Holds out his hand.

Anna looks at the hand. One second. Two.

Then she gives him the notebook – closed.

Jakob sews the binding. Awl, thread, the sounds from that night. He does not open the notebook while he works. Not even halfway. He works on the closed book, more awkwardly

than he would have to.

Anna watches him. Closely. The whole time.

He hands it back. The binding holds.

JAKOB  
The thread is better than the  
notebook.

ANNA  
I know.

**INT. – NIGHT**

*"The Night, Second Time"*

Again the floorboards. Again the yellow circle.

THE NIGHT, A SECOND TIME. But:

The lamp stands on the table, not on the floor. The curtain hangs at a different window. And the whispering woman's voice says words we know:

MOTHER (O.S.)  
(whispering)  
... a place, high above everything  
...

A KNOCK. The bolt. The loud word that does not come through.

The arm stretches into the light: the gun, the mark – hyper-sharp, exactly as the first time. Only everything else has moved.

Whoever was paying attention now mistrusts their own memory for the first time: that is not how it was.

Or is it?

Anna starts out of sleep. Attic, darkness, her breath.

Her lips begin to count.

**Sequence 5 – The City's Lie (~10 min)**

**INT. CORRIDORS OF THE DYING ROOMS – DAY**

*"Carrying Water"*

A long corridor in a house that was once something else. Doors behind which people are dying. VOLUNTEERS carry water

– buckets, jugs, cups.

Anna carries water.

We know this already. It has become her everyday life: another house, the same work, the same gaze. She holds cups, supports arms, sees wrists.

And casually, in the passing of the days: whoever brings water eats along. A DYING WOMAN wordlessly pushes half a plate toward her; an OLD MAN lays bread on the rim of her bucket without looking at her. The dying share what they no longer need.

**INT. A DYING ROOM – DAY**

*"The Old Woman with the Beat, I"*

A bed by the window. THE OLD WOMAN (80s, small, tough). She drinks Anna's water in small sips. Anna lays her notebook on the windowsill. On a leaflet that slips out you can see a headline, "15 Years of Terror," yellowed. The old woman looks at it and taps her fingers on it.

THE OLD WOMAN  
Is that from today?

ANNA  
What? That – no, probably not.

THE OLD WOMAN  
Well? What do you think?

ANNA  
Don't know.

The old woman looks at her. Then she laughs – a short, hard laugh that delivers the beat along with it.

THE OLD WOMAN  
Terrorists don't build power  
plants, child. Nothing could ever  
be fast enough.  
(she taps the beat on the  
edge of the bed)  
Faster. Faster. Faster.

She hands Anna back the glass.

THE OLD WOMAN  
Jahn never convinced me, back  
then. But intent?

Anna takes the glass. Registers it.

**EXT. RUIN BY THE RIVER – EVENING***"JAH ERK"*

The works. Huge, burst open, gnawed at by plants – the ruin of a pride.

Above the main gate, letters three meters tall, half fallen:

**JAH     ERK**

What is missing lies below in the rubble and has been burned, built in, vanished, letter by letter.

Anna walks past along the bank of the river in front of it.

**EXT. THE FIELDS – NIGHT***"The Harvest"*

Beyond the last house: the FIELDS. Man-high stalks as far as the moonlight reaches, a blossoming that looks grey in the dark – and a smell that numbs; you can see it on the faces.

The gang moves out, a dozen children with knives and sacks. Anna goes along; her place is at the back, Jakob beside her.

**LEADER**

(half aloud, walking)

Cut, don't tear.

Cutting is done: umbels, in a rhythm the smallest ones master fastest. Pressed into bales, tied.

At the BARRIER – concrete, wire, a dead floodlight – a section of the barrier is opened from the outside. A hole. The bales change sides without a word. From the other side come chocolate, schnapps, kerosene and cigarettes.

On one of the crates, absurdly clean in all the mud: a LABEL with a curved sign: τ. We know it. From the poster.

Anna cuts, presses, carries. Her share: one bar of chocolate.

**EXT. EDGE OF THE FIELDS – NIGHT***"The Flacon"*

On the way back, where the field turns to mud: something gleams.

Anna bends down. A FLACON – the glass from the poster, gone dull, the beautiful stopper tarnished. Inside: a remnant, a

few drops, darker than water.

She looks around. Nobody. She opens it.

Her knees give way. She sits down in the mud, right in it. Her eyes run over – without anything being sad. Her face knows nothing, only the tears run.

She holds the flacon in both hands like a chick.

That is how Jakob finds her. He is trailing the others a little, as always. He stops. Looks at her, in the mud, with the vial.

He does not ask.

He crouches down next to her, within reach, no closer. After a while, dead serious:

JAKOB  
If you're going to eat them – the  
flowers taste of soap.

Anna laughs. And cries. Both at once, and she cannot explain either.

The stopper goes back on the flacon. The flacon disappears into her jacket, where the notebook lives.

NO INSERT on the vial. No memory. Whoever carries the hideout from the first night may remember. Anna cannot.

**EXT. ROOF – EVENING**  
*"The First Run"*

Over the city comes a sound like a second heart: DRUMS. Not fast. Deep.

Anna is up first – of course she is up first. Jakob follows, grip by grip, grey in the face. He hates heights. He comes anyway. Anna sees it.

From up here, across the street canyon:

The MAIN STREET. Torches, a procession. DRUMMERS at the front, then – two dozen RUNNERS, old men and women, in light clothes. With BARE ARMS.

For the first time in this film, someone displays marks like medals.

Anna, at the edge of the roof. From her jacket: the spyglass.

For the first time through whole lenses – and the first

thing she sees sharp is bare arms in torchlight.

The city stands along the edges of the street, dense, still – and sings. Something half-forgotten, more hum than song – drawn out, heavy, in repetitions, like something that must have come into being at work. It does not sound sad. It does not sound glad either. It sounds old.

At the edge of the city, where the street opens into the fields, the runners begin to run.

Really to run. Like children. Like the mad.

The stalks swallow them one after another. The singing stops, not all at once – it frays. Then only the blossoming is there, and the drumming, which slows like a dying heart. Then that stops too.

#### **EXT. BACK ACROSS THE ROOFS – NIGHT**

*"Only More Honest"*

Two children on a ridge, one behind the other, slow. For a long time nothing but their steps.

Then, without occasion:

JAKOB

The old people say it's like a holiday. Only more honest.

He says it like a joke you have inherited and do not quite understand.

Anna does not answer.

#### **EXT. DISTILLERY COURTYARD – MORNING**

*"The Table the Morning After"*

The morning after the run. Anna has followed the path of the procession – backwards, to where it began – we know the house from before.

The courtyard: kettles, cold, stacked into one another. Wrung-out cloths hang over the wall. Something happened here yesterday that we did not see.

In the middle of the courtyard: a TABLE. On it, in good order: the runners' things. Jackets, folded. A comb. A knife with a horn handle. A pair of boots, soles side by side.

Nobody guards it.

Anna takes her place in the gateway and watches.

Over the course of the morning they come, singly, with time in between: one of the MARKED takes a jacket, holds it against herself for a moment, takes it along. A GANG BOY – at the market he would be loud – takes the knife and is quiet about it. An OLD MAN takes the boots and puts his own in their place, the worse ones.

Nobody takes two things.

Towards noon the table is almost empty. The comb is still there.

Anna has watched the whole time. She leaves without having taken anything.

**INT. A DYING ROOM – DAY**

*"The Old Woman, II: The Wife"*

The old woman again. There is less of her.

Anna refills the water. The old woman, casually, from the middle of a thought:

THE OLD WOMAN

Oh, Jahn could talk. Rosy, but –  
how do you say – not much esprit.  
His jokes always landed nowhere.  
His wife. Now she was pretty. A  
schoolteacher.  
She laughed in his speeches. Right  
into them. The only one who  
understood them – or the only one  
who dared.  
Ah, probably a good man after all.

Anna pours. The cup has long been full.

Anna sets down the jug. And asks – a shade too fast:

ANNA

Have you ever seen a man with a  
mark on his forearm? Here.

She taps the inside of her own forearm.

The old woman looks at her. Properly, for the first time.

And then Anna does something she has never done: she takes out the notebook. Opens the first page – the soft-worn one we have never seen –

– and holds it out to the old woman.

WE SEE ONLY: the back of the page. And above it, the old woman's face.

The old woman looks at it, briefly fascinated.

THE OLD WOMAN

Child.

(pause)

Everyone here is marked.

Anna closes the notebook. Puts it away. Takes the jug and goes without turning around.

### Sequence 6 – The Good Days (~16 min)

#### EXT. WATER TOWER – DAY

*"The Missing Step"*

Anna climbs the water tower – routine, grip by grip, the highest point of the quarter. At the top, from her jacket: the spyglass.

She looks out over the city.

Suddenly a HILL, at the far end, behind an old depot. A path turning upward in switchbacks, a railing as a thin line – and at one point, where the path disappears behind the sheds, it breaks off. A gap in the picture.

Like a staircase with one step missing.

Anna looks. Looks away. Looks again.

#### EXT. PATH TO THE LOOKOUT – DAY

*"The Ascent"*

The path in switchbacks, the railing: rusty, gone in places.

Anna walks ahead – and her lips are counting. Soundless, out of habit, out of something older than habit. She does not notice it herself.

Jakob is along too, at the back. Pale. Carefully he walks behind her.

#### EXT. LOOKOUT – DAY

*"The Panorama"*

At the top.

The wide view: the whole city at once. The ruin with its fallen letters. The fields, a grey sea to the horizon. The barrier: a thin line. And beyond it, incomprehensibly –

world. Simply going on.

Jakob arrives, his eyes opening wide. He tries to breathe the view in. He comes to stand next to Anna. We see both faces.

For the first time Anna stands at a high place and is not alone. Jakob, with his fear of heights, all the more so.

Anna takes his hand.

**EXT. PATH DOWN FROM THE LOOKOUT – DAY**

*"Gone as in Gone"*

The way back, in switchbacks. Anna ahead, Jakob behind, one hand on the railing where there is one.

ANNA

Has anyone ever gone through, back there?

JAKOB

(without stopping)

One of the gang – his uncle knew someone who tried.

ANNA

And?

Jakob shrugs. It is not a shrug. It is the entire answer.

JAKOB

Gone.

ANNA

Gone as in through? Or gone as in gone?

JAKOB

Gone as in never seen again.

**EXT./INT. OLD CINEMA – LATE AFTERNOON**

*"The Cinema"*

Anna and Jakob walking, a route like any other: lanes, dead shops, facades with their lids down.

Then Jakob stops.

Above an entrance Anna would not have looked at: a CANOPY on thin struts. Beneath it, behind blind glass, a LETTER BOARD – black grooves, push-in letters. Some letters have fallen or been taken; what stands, stands with gaps – the way the ruin by the river carries its name.

The programme from back then. Three lines, three titles, half readable. Nobody ever took them down. The same week has been playing for ten years.

JAKOB

Come.

And he is already inside.

INSIDE, THE HALL: high, dark, cool. Jakob's steps know the way.

Light falls through a burst skylight. The floor: empty. No chairs, no benches – only SCREW HOLES in the screed, in rows, dozens of them, like a dictation without words.

The seat rows have been burned.

At the front: the SCREEN – what is left of it. A remnant, cut away at a slant; cloth is precious. The frame still shows how big it was.

Anna stands among the screw holes and looks around. She catalogues – and arrives at nothing.

ANNA

What was this?

JAKOB

They threw light at the wall here. Stories.

(pause)

Everyone looked in the same direction. There were chairs here, in rows.

Anna looks at the remnant of the screen. Then across the screw holes, the rows. She tries to imagine people, that many, all with the same gaze. You can see that she does not manage it.

JAKOB (CONT'D)

Come on, it gets even better.

THE PROJECTION BOOTH: a steep stair, a cubicle with a view of the hall. In it, under a tarpaulin: the PROJECTOR.

Jakob lifts the tarpaulin off. Metal, lenses, a crank. His reflex reaches out ahead of him: he opens a flap, turns, checks. The machine is heavy and whole. It could be saved.

Jakob's eyes search the booth, the shelves. Empty tin canisters, stacked, open.

JAKOB  
(dry; the speedometer  
tone)  
It works. There is just nothing  
left to put in.

Anna, at the booth door:

ANNA  
I have no idea what you're talking  
about.

JAKOB  
Must have been great, back then.

They go. At the door Anna turns around once more.

Through the open door the afternoon falls into the hall – a  
bright, slanted RECTANGLE on what is left of the screen.

It is the only picture this cinema still shows. It runs as  
long as the door stands open.

**INT. WORKSHOP FLAT – MORNING**

*"Ruth's Good Day, I: The Condensed Milk"*

Ruth's good day. She is half sitting up, there is light in  
the room, and she is talking.

RUTH  
Ten years now they've been  
throwing crates out of the sky at  
us. You know what I've kept, out  
of that whole sky?  
(pause)  
The condensed milk.

Jakob grins over his work. Anna, at the table, laughs her  
nose-laugh.

**INT. WORKSHOP FLAT – MIDDAY**

*"Ruth's Good Day, II: Anton"*

The light has wandered. Ruth is lying down again. Her gaze  
finds Jakob, and something in it has slipped.

RUTH  
Anton. The window.

Silence.

He closes the window. He holds her hand until she sleeps.

Anna watches.

**INT. WORKSHOP FLAT – EVENING**

*"Ruth's Good Day, III: Jakob"*

The light is almost gone. Ruth wakes. She looks at Jakob – quite clear, clearer than all day.

RUTH

Jakob.

Once. Right. She reaches for his hand.

Jakob holds still, mid-movement.

She says no more. She falls asleep again.

**EXT. WORKSHOP YARD – NIGHT**

*"Lenz Drinks Nothing"*

The window of the workshop flat: lit, small. Inside, Jakob sits at the bed.

In the yard stands the man from the market.

LENZ (late 50s, gaunt, long sleeves; hands that were once good at something). Jakob's father.

Beside him, on the ledge of the wall: a bottle. Schnapps, full, the cork in.

Lenz stands and drinks nothing.

LATER. The light in the window has grown small.

Jakob sits at the bed. He rises and stands at the bed for a long time, without moving.

Then he opens the window. Wide.

Lenz looks at the open window. He understands it the way you understand something you have waited for all night.

He sits down on the ledge, next to the full bottle. He leaves it closed.

That is how the two of them stay, each on his side of the night: the boy at the open window, the man beside the full bottle. Until it grows light.

A quiet death.

**EXT. WASTELAND / BURIAL GROUND – DAY**

*"The Small Funeral"*

A piece of wasteland the city has turned into something

like this – rows of flat stones, wooden markers without names.

There are no coffins; wood is warmth. The dead are sewn into cloths, the flat stones from the ruins lie against the dogs. No names stand here.

Ruth's cloth is neatly sewn. The seam is fine.

Few people. Jakob. Lenz, two steps beside him – two steps that nobody closes. The leader has come, with two of the gang; they stand at the back holding their caps in their hands, and you can see: they have done this too often for their age. Behind them, the cart from scene 29, "The Mender."

Words are spoken, few. We do not hear them. We do not need to.

Anna stands at the edge, where you stand when you belong to nobody.

**EXT. CITY – DAY**

*"How the Home Fell"*

After the grave. They walk

For a long time, nothing.

Then, into the walking, without a run-up:

ANNA

At the home I knew things. Where  
the sugar was. Who crossed the  
yard at night.

Jakob does not look at her. That is his way of listening.

ANNA

Everyone wanted sugar. I handed it  
out. For half a loaf.

JAKOB

And if they'd caught you?

ANNA

Not me.

Jakob nods.

ANNA

One of the houseparents stole.  
From the rations, for years.  
Everyone knew.

(pause)

Once, there hung a slip of paper  
from over there on one. With the  
number of rations.

JAKOB

And?

ANNA

Left it at the administration.

JAKOB

And then?

ANNA

Waited.

Jakob almost stops walking. Then he laughs – the laughter  
that falls over, in the middle of the street, on the day of  
a funeral. He is embarrassed at once and keeps laughing.

JAKOB

Waited how. Until someone reads  
it?

ANNA

Was safer.

JAKOB

(still laughing)  
And the houseparent?

ANNA

Then the home was over.

Jakob looks at her from the side – long. For the first time  
since the grave his face is not grey anymore.

#### **INT. WORKSHOP FLAT – DAY**

*"The Prompter"*

The room is the same and is not: the bed Ruth lay in is  
made. The tools on the wall, tidy. The cot empty.

LENZ sits at the table. In front of him stands water he  
does not touch. He is sober.

ANNA sits on the stool opposite – which she has turned,  
without thinking, toward the door. Jakob is out getting  
food.

LENZ

The fields. Four in the morning,  
in summer. That's when the smell  
was best – before the sun, while  
the dew still holds it down. We

ran, to be out there by four. Ran.  
To work.

Anna turns toward him.  
Lenz looks at her. For a long time. Almost a smile.

LENZ  
I had a friend who couldn't tell a  
joke. Cleverest man I ever –  
(breaks off, starts again)  
He could explain a plant to you  
till you wept, it was that  
beautiful. But a joke, three  
sentences – he couldn't carry one  
across the street in one piece. He  
always gave the punch line first.  
Always. Worried you might miss it.

Anna listens the way she listens to everyone. Her eyes go  
once, casually, to his sleeves. Buttoned.

ANNA  
(casually; the casualness  
of an investigator)  
What was his name?

A breath. Lenz's thumb rubs along the edge of the table.

LENZ  
My friend.

Anna registers it.  
And Lenz talks on as if nothing had been asked:

LENZ (CONT'D)  
Ruth always thought him a bit  
stiff – she liked his girl better.  
(smiling to himself) The two of  
them always had plenty to laugh  
about....  
I prompted him. For years. I stood  
next to him like at the theatre.  
Sometimes I fed him his own jokes,  
half aloud, and people laughed,  
and he took the bow.  
(pause)  
That was my best one. That nobody  
noticed who was telling it.

Anna says nothing. But she does not get up.

LENZ (CONT'D)  
This one he never got across the  
street in one piece. Watch.

He straightens up. Barely. But he straightens up.

LENZ (CONT'D)  
 A man asks the drunkard: why do  
 you drink? Says the drunkard: to  
 forget. Asks the other: forget  
 what?

Lenz lets the pause stand. Exactly as long as it must.

LENZ (CONT'D)  
 Can't remember.  
 (beat)  
 So it's working.

Anna laughs. Once, short, through the nose. Against her will.

Lenz looks up as if a light had come on. He goes to the window, sees nothing.

LENZ  
 (quietly)  
 Another?

**EXT. STREET / X-STREET – DAY**  
*"Stay"*

Anna, alone, on one of her rounds.

On the other side of the street, at a trot: the DOG.

Anna stops. He does not. He has not seen her.

She follows him. Not like someone calling – like someone watching: at a distance, along the house walls.

The dog slips through a half-collapsed archway – and is gone.

At the corner: a CHALK X, hip-high, retraced many times.

Anna stands before the X. The dog is beyond it.

Chalk does not apply to dogs. The pigeons nest where nobody goes – the X-streets are the best hunting ground in the city, and it belongs to no one, because no one enters it.

Anna looks up the street, down the street. Nobody.

Then she walks past the X.

THE X-STREET: quiet in a way the city does not otherwise know. The facades are standing. Behind them stands nothing – through the windows you see sky. What was wood has been burned; what was metal has been built into other things. The houses have been eaten hollow: faces with nothing left

behind them to carry.

Everywhere: PIGEONS. On the ledges, in the window holes, under the eaves. The only place in the city where something lives in abundance.

The dog is on a BALCONY on the first floor – up a slope of rubble. Under the eaves: nests.

Then he sees Anna.

He goes still. Completely still. Ears forward.

Anna comes closer, below, in the street. Slowly. She wants to say something – and has nothing. She never gave him a name. There is no word to call him with.

Her hand rises. Halfway. Flat.

The dog stays.

Anna slowly climbs the same slope of rubble.

At first it is only a trickle. Plaster, a fine curtain of dust. The dog looks at Anna, Anna looks at the dog.

Then the balcony tears out of the wall.

No sound from him. Only the house: a breaking, a blow, dust taking half the street. The ground shakes. Once.

Then the dust stands in the air, and nothing else.

Anna digs. With her hands, without a sound, stone by stone. She digs until she reaches a slab that will not lift. She tries anyway. Then she stops trying.

She kneels in the rubble and is fourteen years old.

Then she stacks back the stones she has lifted. Flat, one on the other, neatly. We know these stones. This is how they lie at the burial ground – against the dogs.

She goes. After a few seconds. The pigeons come back, one after another, onto the ledges, into the window holes.

### **Sequence 7 – The Child of the Lie (~12 min)**

**INT. WORKSHOP FLAT – DAY**  
*"The Mayor"*

Another day. Jakob is out.

When Anna knocks, the two cups are already standing on the table.

Lenz has grown thinner; it is going fast now. On his neck, above the collar: a new mark.

He sees Anna's gaze – the gaze that always falls on marks, she cannot switch it off. He points his thumb at it, with the precision of an expert:

LENZ

This one's new. I call him the mayor. Sits at the top and does nothing.

His laugh is dry as kindling.

Anna looks closer. Under the collar, half hidden: another one.

ANNA

There's another one under your chin.

LENZ

The deputy.

Anna laughs through her nose. Lenz looks at her with that hungry gaze, and for a moment these are two people who are doing well.

The clock on him is running. We can see it now with the naked eye.

**EXT. WASTELAND / BURIAL GROUND – DAY**

*"Anton"*

Ruth's stone. Jakob crouches in front of it, straightening what has not slipped: the flat stone, the wooden marker. Work that is none. Anna stands beside him.

For a long time, nothing.

ANNA

Who is Anton?

Jakob moves the stone a finger's width. And back again.

JAKOB

My brother. Never met him.  
Died back then, in the night, with  
the others. He was two. That's all  
I know.

ANNA

Hm. Weird.

JAKOB

Mama doesn't mean it badly.

Anna looks at him.

Anna sits down on the remnant of wall beside the grave. And pays back:

ANNA

I don't know who mine were.  
Parents.

(pause)

I have voices. Whispering, nothing  
more. One word that was loud –  
once. And a story that keeps  
coming back and somehow stops.

JAKOB

Will you tell it to me sometime?

ANNA

(after a while)

Perhaps.

They stay until it slowly grows dark.

**INT. WORKSHOP FLAT – DAY***"The Chairs"*

Another day, the same water he does not drink. The routines grow darker; they slide closer to something.

LENZ

I once set up chairs in a hall. A  
whole night. Four hundred chairs.  
For an assembly, in the morning –  
it was to be the celebration –  
(he aligns invisible rows  
of chairs)  
Chairs, child. I hauled chairs for  
the future. And then..

Break-off.

But nothing more comes. Lenz struggles for composure. Then, out of nowhere:

LENZ

How old are you?

ANNA  
Fourteen.

Lenz nods.

Then he gets up, puts away the cup.

**INT. ATTIC – NIGHT**  
*"Sentences Side by Side"*

Anna lies awake, eyes open, the skylight a grey rectangle.

And the sentences come, repeating. As voices, quiet, out of the dark – in her head, with us as witnesses:

RUTH (O.S.)  
Anna, let me look at you...

THE OLD WOMAN (O.S.)  
... a schoolteacher. She laughed  
in his speeches ...

MOTHER (O.S.)  
... a place, high above everything  
...

LENZ (O.S.)  
How old are you?

Silence.

Anna sits up.

She looks to the skylight. Sets out.

**EXT./INT. THE HOME, ARCHIVE WINDOW – NIGHT**  
*"I Have Tea"*

The home at night, from outside: grown darker. Somewhere a little light is burning.

Anna climbs. The archive window she knows from before: the latch that does not quite close.

She slips inside –

In the archive room a light is burning.

THE PENCIL sits at the small table between the shelves. In front of him: a pot, two cups.

Two.

THE PENCIL

I have tea.

As if that were an explanation.

Anna stands at the window, half in, half out.

She comes all the way in.

He pours. The pot does not tremble.

THE PENCIL

"Tea is the only drink that makes  
time stand still."

(pause)

That was in a book. The book has  
been burned for warmth. The  
sentence has not. Hello, Anna.

ANNA

(taken aback)

Hello.

Anna drinks. It is the best thing anyone has offered her in weeks.

Anna looks around. In one corner the Pencil has set up a makeshift place to sleep. A candle, a few books.

THE PENCIL

I always cook for two.

# **INT. ARCHIVE – NIGHT**

*"The Little Horse"*

Shelves, files, the remains of an administration. Anna stands at the table.

ANNA

My intake. There has to be  
something. A paper. Anything.

The Pencil looks at her. Then he gets up – and fetches no paper.

From the lowest shelf, behind the files: a small bundle of cloth, tied, ten years of dust in its folds.

He lays it in front of her and unwraps it, carefully, with his long grey fingers.

Inside lies a WOODEN LITTLE HORSE.

Small, smooth to the hand, the mane almost loved away – a thing that has spent a thousand hours in a child's hand.

THE PENCIL

This was with you when you came.

Anna does not move.

ANNA

Who brought me?

THE PENCIL

That I don't know. Not anymore,  
probably. The horse I hid back  
then, just in case. ...

It fits her hand as if the hand had waited ten years for  
nothing else. Her thumb finds a spot on the mane by itself.

The notebook in her pocket grows heavy as a millstone. She  
does not reach for it.

We understand one second before her, and then she  
understands.

**INT. – NIGHT**

*"The Night, Third Time"*

THE NIGHT, A THIRD TIME. The strangest:

The room is almost empty. The furniture wrong, too little  
of it, in the wrong places. Where the vial stood: nothing.

And the voices are exchanged – the woman's voice,  
whispering, says the man's words; the man's voice is a  
sound without words.

In the hand of the child under the table lies,  
matter-of-factly, as if it had always been there:

the little horse.

(Was it there? Was it ever there?)

A KNOCK. The bolt. The door.

And the father's loud word – ten years long nothing but  
sound – is for the first time almost language: two  
syllables.

Two syllables that could be "Lorenz." Or anything else.

Whether memory finally releases the word or is only now  
building it cannot be decided. We have just seen what it  
can do with a little horse.

The arm stretches into the light. The gun. The mark.  
Hyper-sharp – the only thing that always stays the same.

And we no longer believe it a single image.

**EXT. ROOF OF THE HOME – NIGHT**

*"The Overlay"*

Anna sits on the ridge of the home, where she sat as a child. Below her the dark house, before her the darker city.

The little horse in her fist. The notebook on her knees.

Anna's hand lies on the first page of the notebook.

She does not open it.

**INT. CLASSROOM, THE HOME – NIGHT**

*"The Fourth Face"*

The way down from the roof leads through the house. A corridor, an open door: the classroom. Moonlight on empty benches.

Anna means to pass. And goes in.

On the wall the chart still hangs. The works, proud, seen from below. In front of it, small, the four people with the flags.

Anna has looked at this picture for a thousand hours and never seen it.

Three faces are scratched out, the grey shiny with years. The fourth nobody has touched: a young woman, laughing, a child on her arm.

Anna knows the face. She last saw it when there was less of it left.

Ruth.

And next to her, one of the scratched-out ones: the face is gone, the bearing has stayed. She stands turned a little, and one hand lies on the dress, low, the way hands lie when they are guarding something.

Anna stands before the picture for a long time and strokes the woman's belly.

**EXT. DISTILLERY, WALL – DAY**

*"The Chalk List"*

The old distillery: a long brick building, dead chimneys, the smell of back then long gone from the walls.

On the yard wall: NAMES. Written in chalk, one below the other, some weathered, some fresh. A list nobody administers and everybody respects.

JAKOB stands in front of the wall. Alone.

His gaze goes down the names – and catches.

There, in neat, old-fashioned handwriting, with the full name, first and last, fresh:

**LORENZ KESSLER**

Jakob stands very still.

**EXT. OUTSIDE THE WORKSHOP – DAY**

*"The Request"*

Anna comes – and Jakob is already standing there, outside the door, as if he had not been able to go in.

JAKOB

He put himself on it. Properly.  
Full name.

Anna understands at once what is meant.

JAKOB

Lorenz Kessler.

Silence.

Something sounds in Anna – two syllables, deep under ten years. Or she is building it in this moment. It cannot be decided, not for her, not for us.

Her face does nothing. That is work, and you can see the work.

Then, for the first time since we have known him, Jakob wants something:

JAKOB

You're quick. You think of things.  
Help me get him down off there.

Anna – who has never refused him a request, because he never had one – says nothing.

One second. Two. One second too long.

Jakob looks at her. Sees something he cannot name.

JAKOB

You look at him like your  
grown-ups.  
Like one out of your notebook.

ANNA

Get him down. How. Tell me how.

JAKOB

You think of things everywhere  
else. With the sugar. With the  
lists. With your dog you thought  
of something too –

ANNA

The dog was a toll.

JAKOB

The dog was yours. You didn't even  
wait for them to take hold of him.  
You nodded and you walked.

ANNA

And you climbed after me onto  
every roof, grey as ash, and never  
said a word. You hid your father  
from me. I see everything.

(pause)

You take a look at him. He doesn't  
have long – wall or no wall.

(calm)

And if that is his last wish, then  
let him go.

JAKOB

Yes. You see everything. And say  
nothing. You sit with him, you  
listen to him, for weeks – and the  
one time I need something, you  
calculate.

ANNA

I don't calculate –

JAKOB

I watched. One second. You  
calculated like at the toll.

Anna is silent.

JAKOB

People who only ever take – those  
I know. The whole city takes. I  
thought –

He breaks off. He does not say what he thought.

Jakob goes. Anna stays standing and looks after him.

**EXT. OUTSIDE THE WORKSHOP – NIGHT**

*"The Spyglass at the Door"*

Anna does not come to knock.

Through the window, out of the dark of the alley: inside, the small lamp is burning. Jakob sits by the cot – on which the father now lies, sleeping; for the first time we see Lenz on this bed. Jakob simply sits there. Keeping watch.

Then she steps to the door. From her jacket: the spyglass.

She sets it on the threshold. Centered. Properly.

And goes.

**Sequence 8 – The Run (~9 min)**

**EXT. DISTILLERY COURTYARD – MORNING**

*"The Washing" · "The Writing on the Arms" · "The Perhaps" · "The Lit*

Cold in which you can see breath. Kettles of warm water, carried by VOLUNTEERS – nobody assigns them, they come of their own accord. The dying arrange it themselves.

Steam stands over the courtyard.

The RUNNERS, a dozen, lay down what they have carried: jackets, shirts, things. A TABLE for the things. Nobody guards it.

The volunteers wash those who run today. Arms, face, neck – slow, thorough, without ceremony. It looks like what it is: people washing people.

And with the laying down and the washing there are – arms. Bare arms, everywhere in the courtyard, marks in every script. What the city has shrouded since we have known it is simply here. Nobody points at it. It is the only place where it means nothing.

On the other side of the courtyard: LENZ, with bare arms.

Marks, many, old and new – a whole script. We see him without sleeves for the first time, and it is as if we were seeing a man naked for the first time.

Before him JAKOB. The camera's gaze catches his shoes.

Freshly mended. Seams as fine as only one man makes them.

Jakob says nothing. Lenz says nothing.

Then the father's hands rise. Halfway. At half height they stop and fall back down.

Between the two stands fourteen years of air.

ANNA stands at the edge.

Anna's gaze does what her gaze always does. It falls on the arms.

The steam opens. Two seconds, three: on the inner forearm, among many – a mark in the shape of the horse's head.

Perhaps. Perhaps not. The steam moves back in between.

NO INSERT. NO CLOSENESS. NO MUSIC. We are too far away to swear to it, and we stay too far away.

Anna closes her eyes.

She opens them again. Now she looks at his face. Lenz returns the gaze. Briefly, then back to Jakob.

Again we are on Anna.

Then she walks to the table with the laid-down things. Lays, between the jackets and shirts, the wooden little horse. She simply does it.

The camera stays with her and with the table until she turns away.

**EXT. MAIN STREET – DAY**  
*"The Procession"*

The DRUMS set in, deep, like a second heart.

The procession: the drummers at the front, then the runners, in light clothes, with bare arms. Lenz among them – more upright than we have ever seen him, and not yet upright.

The city stands along the edges, dense. And sings the half-forgotten thing. Closer now, close enough for words – a work song, drawn out and heavy: one line that repeats as if it had to keep a back straight, and a third that answers.

**Early at four, before the sun stands high,**

**early at four, before the sun stands high,**

**I go into the dew, before the dew goes dry.**

Old voices carry the words; the children know them only half and hum the gaps. It is the harvest song. The city sings after its runners what it sang all its life on the way to work.

JAKOB runs the first stretch along the edge, level with his father.

The corner where the street opens into the fields. There the living stop. That is the rule nobody explains.

Jakob stops. The procession runs on. From behind, Anna comes running up.

#### **EXT. THE FIELDS – DAY**

*"The Supernova"*

The street becomes a field path, the path becomes a trace, the stalks stand man-high and blossom.

At the edge of the fields the runners begin to run.

Really to run. Like children. Like the mad.

And Lenz runs.

In the running something straightens up in him that we have taken for dead the whole film: the shoulders come back. The stride takes hold. The field worker finds a ground he knows – this ground, there is no other he knows like this.

The stalks close over the first one. Over the second.

Just before the blossoming takes him, Lenz turns his face into the smell – the best nose in the city, in the smell of its life –

and LAUGHS.

Then there is only the field.

The drumming slows. Stops.

#### **EXT. CITY / PATH TO THE HILL – DAY**

*"The Stillness After"*

The city is very still.

Anna and Jakob walk side by side. Without touching. Without talking.

Around Jakob's neck, on a new strap, fine seams: the spyglass.

They walk the path up the hill, in switchbacks, along the railing.

**EXT. LOOKOUT — DAWN**  
*"The Story, Aloud"*

The city below is grey and still and complete. The thin line of the barrier. Beyond it: world, simply going on.

ANNA and JAKOB sit side by side at the railing. Not touching. The distance: a hand's width.

For a long time, nothing. Then:

ANNA  
Mama always talked about us  
sitting above the city one day. I  
think it's here.

Jakob does not look at her. That is his way of listening.

Anna looks at the city. Then she recites it — not the way you tell, the way you recite: a text that has been by heart for ten years.

ANNA  
High above everything there is a  
place. You take the path that  
turns, always by the railing, and  
you count the steps. And at the  
top the whole city lies at your  
feet, like an open book. And in  
the evening comes the —

She holds.

Not like someone thinking. Like someone walking a staircase in the dark, one they know — and the step is not there.

Jakob does not ask.

JAKOB  
(quietly)  
Go on.

ANNA  
— and it lays itself over  
everything, and everything that is  
broken looks whole from up there.  
At this place we promised you your  
life. And whoever has been up  
there knows: behind the city the  
world does not end. When you are  
big, we will go up, we three. And  
you will count the steps.

Pause.

Jakob nods. Looks at the city, the barrier, the thin line.

JAKOB  
Mine kept nothing from the Drops  
but the condensed milk.

Anna laughs. Quietly, through the nose. She does not lean against him. She only sits a little less alone.

Then Jakob lays his hand on the railing, next to hers.

**EXT. ROAD TO THE BARRIER – DAY**  
*"The Sign"*

A road between fields, toward the thin line on the horizon.

At the roadside, crooked in the earth: an official SIGN from before. The lettering almost gone, eaten by weather:

**RESTRICTED AREA**

**NO ENTRY**

Nobody looks at it.

Two children walk beneath it, each with a bundle, toward the horizon behind which the world simply goes on.

**EXT. THE GANG'S WALL – DAY**  
*"The Dog"*

On a wall, far behind them, at the edge of the territory:  
the yellow DOG.

He sits and watches them go, the two shrinking figures between the fields.

He does not run after them.

Whether they get through, we do not see. The hope of a way out weighs more.

BLACK.

**THE END.**